

The Australian Government has invested \$5 million from 2023 to 2027 to develop a renewed Australian Animal Welfare Strategy (AAWS) using a joint leadership approach with state and territory governments.

## Vision of the AAWS

Australia achieves good animal welfare outcomes through the development and adoption of animal welfare practices and standards that are underpinned by science and evidence.

The vision statement described the aspiration for the future of Australia's animal welfare system. The vision, developed through an extensive consultation process, will guide the delivery of the AAWS, alongside the [key principles](#) agreed by all Ministers.

## What is being delivered?

The government is strengthening a national approach to animal welfare by investing \$5 million over 4 years (2023-2027) to renew the Australian Animal Welfare Strategy (AAWS).

The Australian Government is working closely with states and territories to take a joint leadership approach to renewing the AAWS.

The budget for this commitment was announced as part of the May 2023 budget.

In March 2024, Australian and state and territory agriculture ministers committed to jointly leading the renewal of the AAWS, informed by broad stakeholder engagement and a [principles-based framework](#).

To underpin the development of the AAWS, Ministers reaffirmed their commitment through the [National Statement on Animal Welfare](#).

The renewed AAWS will include 6 animal group chapters, with the strategy expected to be finalised by mid-2027.

Want to see how the renewal is progressing? Visit the [Roadmap and progress page](#) for the latest updates.

## Why it matters

The renewed AAWS will:

- Establish a national framework, bringing together key stakeholders on issues of national significance
- provide a forward direction to address industry, community and international expectations
- maintain Australia's commitment to modern, sustainable, evidence and science-based animal welfare practice

- demonstrate Australia's strong animal welfare standards, which will support increased access to overseas markets, and strengthen the reputation of our animal and agricultural industries with trading partners.

Guided by the principles-based framework agreed to by all Agriculture Ministers in 2024, the AAWS will:

- promote national consistency across its key priorities and actions to provide certainty to industry and consumers
- promote good animal welfare outcomes across its key priorities and actions
- be trusted by the community, consumers, industry and trading partners
- establish key priorities and actions that deliver sustainable improvements for the welfare of all animals
- consider contemporary animal welfare science with priorities that meet current challenges and opportunities
- establish a pathway for improved measurable animal welfare outcomes
- contribute to Australia's sustainable international trade credentials, maintaining and securing future market access by showcasing and maturing Australia's national approach to animal welfare

## Governance structure

[Animal welfare within Australia](#) is generally a state and territory responsibility. However, there is a collaborative approach to managing animal welfare that requires the cooperation of all layers of government and the broader animal welfare system.

The governance structure for the Australian Animal Welfare Strategy (AAWS) provides oversight of the all-animal scope of the AAWS.

The governance framework uses existing mechanisms to support joint leadership and cooperation on animal welfare. This is primarily through the cross-jurisdictional [Animal Welfare Task Group \(AWTG\)](#). Australia's Agriculture Ministers provide final oversight through the Agriculture Ministers' Meeting (AMM).

These existing mechanisms will be supported by an Australian Government cross-portfolio Sponsor Group, to capture input on animal welfare issues by responsible portfolio agencies.

The AWTG is a subgroup of the Agriculture Senior Officials' Committee (AGSOC). The AWTG has officials from the Australian Government, and state and territory governments. The New Zealand government is also a part of AWTG, as an observer.

Read more about the [Animal Welfare Task Group](#).

The Agriculture Senior Officials' Committee (AGSOC) is a forum for agency heads to coordinate, cooperate and collaborate on matters affecting Australia's primary production sectors. AGSOC membership comprises of heads of departments with portfolio responsibility for biosecurity, agricultural production, and trade from each jurisdiction.

Agriculture Ministers' Meeting (AMM) comprises of Australian and state and territory agriculture ministers. They work collaboratively on national issues relating to the agriculture sector, including fisheries and forestry.

Read the [AMM communiques](#).

Other Australian Government agencies also have responsibilities for animal welfare.

The Australian Government cross-portfolio Sponsor Group is a key part of the governance structure supporting the renewal of the AAWS.

The Sponsor Group includes representation from:

- Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water
- The Department of Health, Disability and Ageing:
  - National Health and Medical Research Council
  - Therapeutic Goods Administration.

## Strategy Advisory Group

A four-member Strategy Advisory Group (SAG) has been established as part of the governance structure, to support the renewal of the Australian Animal Welfare Strategy (AAWS).

The SAG will provide strategic advice to the department at key stages of the AAWS renewal process. It does not make decisions about the strategy.

SAG members are not representative of a particular organisation or sector, and bring a range of experience that will support the renewal of the AAWS.

- Chair – Deputy Secretary, Agricultural Trade and Regulation Group, DAFF
- Deputy Chair – First Assistant Secretary, Plant and Live Animal Exports, Welfare and Regulation Division, Agricultural Trade and Regulation Group, DAFF

Professor Alan Tilbrook

Professor Tilbrook currently holds the position of Professor of Animal Welfare at The University of Queensland, with a joint appointment in the Queensland Alliance for Agriculture and Food Innovation and the School of Veterinary Science. Nationally and internationally recognised for his expertise in animal welfare, his research disciplines include endocrinology, neuroendocrinology, stress psychology, animal welfare science, behaviour and reproduction. He has conducted research across various species, including sheep, pigs, poultry, cattle, goats, buffalo, rodents, horses, and humans.

Professor Tilbrook played pivotal roles as a co-founder, Deputy Director, and Co-Director of the Animal Welfare Science Centre, as well as the Co-founder and Director of The Animal Welfare Collaborative. Moreover, he holds the position of Chair and Research Champion of the National Primary Industries Animal Welfare Research, Development, and Extension Strategy. Professor Tilbrook is a board member

of the Australian & New Zealand Council for the Care of Animals in Research and Teaching (ANZCCART), representing Universities Australia and a member of the World Organisation for Animal Health.

Dr Bonny Cumming

Dr Bonny Cumming is an experienced veterinarian with a broad range of strategic planning and project management skills. With a career focused on One Health principles, she integrates community development, public health, veterinary services, and environmental conservation to enhance the wellbeing of animals, humans, and ecosystems. Raised on Jarowair and Giabal land on the outskirts of Toowoomba, Dr Cumming's career has exposed her to an incredible diversity of species, environments, and contexts—from busy wildlife triage hospitals to research with elephant seals in Antarctica, and from working as a general practitioner delivering individual animal veterinary care to designing and implementing companion animal population health strategies in remote Australian communities.

Dr Cumming holds the position of Head of Innovation and Strategy at AMRRIC (Animal Management in Rural and Remote Indigenous Communities), where she has worked since 2013. In this role, she develops, delivers, and evaluates strategic remote Indigenous community animal management initiatives, involving on-ground animal health and biosecurity capacity-building training, advocacy, and One Health focused research. Since 2018, Dr Cumming has additionally been a Project Manager at The University of Melbourne Veterinary School. Through this work, she has managed multi-disciplinary and multi-institutional One Health, biosecurity and emergency animal disease research and capacity development collaborations.

Dr Cumming holds a Bachelor of Veterinary Science with First Class Honours (University of Queensland, 2008), a Masters of Veterinary Studies in Conservation Medicine (Murdoch University, 2012). Her professional journey reflects a deep commitment to advancing veterinary science and enhancing community health through innovative and inclusive strategies.

## **The previous AAWS**

The original strategy, which lapsed in 2014, was an overarching national framework that identified priorities, coordinated stakeholder action, and improved consistency across all animal use sectors.

Reflecting its complexity, the strategy took five years to develop, commencing in June 1999. The AAWS was finalised in 2004, with endorsement by the then Council of Australian Governments' (COAG) Primary Industries Ministerial Council in May of that year.

The strategy's first national implementation plan was endorsed in 2006.

In 2010, the strategy was updated after stakeholder consultation and an independent review. At its conclusion, the strategy was in its implementation phase, supported by a range of working groups.

The renewed AAWS will build on successes of the previous strategy while reflecting contemporary animal welfare science and evidence and recognising modern challenges and opportunities.

**See more**



Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/animal/welfare/aaws/the-renewed-aaws>